

The Great Sūtra Called Emptiness

Śūnyatā-nāma-mahāsūtra · Toh 290 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 290 in the Kangyur is a sūtra known in English as The Great Sūtra Called Emptiness, in Sanskrit as the Śūnyatā-nāma-mahāsūtra, and in Tibetan as Mdo chen po stong pa nyid ces bya ba. It belongs to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras and takes as its central concern the Buddha's direct teaching on emptiness, presented through a dialogue between the Buddha and his attendant Ānanda at the Eastern Park in Śrāvastī. The exchange is prompted by Ānanda's recollection of a statement the Buddha had once made among the Śākya — that he dwells repeatedly in emptiness — and his wish to understand its deeper meaning. As a "great sūtra" dedicated entirely to this theme, the text offers a sustained and focused exposition of emptiness as a meditative reality and a fundamental characteristic of experience.

In the language of India: Śūnyatā-nāma-mahāsūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Great Sūtra Called Emptiness.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Eastern Park, in the mansion of Mṛgāramāṭṛ.

Then the venerable Ānanda, rising from meditative composure in the late afternoon, went to where the Blessed One was, and having gone there, he bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One and sat to one side. Seated to one side, the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One in these words:

"Reverend One, there was a time when the Blessed One was dwelling among the Śākya, in the Śākya market town called Śākyaṇaṃ. At that time the Blessed One declared these words to me: 'Ānanda, I dwell repeatedly in emptiness.' I wish to know the meaning of what the Blessed One declared. Reverend One, is it that what the Blessed One spoke, and what I heard well and grasped well, kept well in mind, practiced well, and understood well — is that not other than what was meant, but exactly as it was?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, it is just so. What I spoke, and what you heard well and grasped well, practiced well, and understood well — that is not otherwise; it is exactly as it was. And why is that? Ānanda, it is because both then and now I dwell repeatedly in emptiness.

"Ānanda, consider this example. This mansion of Mṛgāramāṭṛ is empty of elephants, horses, cattle, sheep, chickens, and pigs; empty of wealth, grain, goods, and gold; and empty of male and female servants, workers, and those who live on buttermilk, and of men, women, boys, and girls. And yet there is this much that is not empty here, namely: the community of monks alone, or something pertaining to that.

"Ānanda, in just the same way, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it. And whatever remains present there — that is rightly and accurately known to exist there. Ānanda, this is the entry into emptiness exactly as it is, without distortion.

"Ānanda, therefore, if a monk should wish: 'May I dwell repeatedly in emptiness,' then, Ānanda, that monk should not attend to the perception of village or the perception of people, but should attend to the perception of forest — or at least to something pertaining to that. He should think to himself: 'This type of perception — the perception of village and the perception of people — is empty here. And yet there is this much that is not empty here, namely: the perception of forest alone, or something pertaining to that.' And while those bases of affliction that depend on the perception of village and the perception of people are absent, there do remain those bases of affliction that depend on the perception of forest alone, or something pertaining to that.

"Ānanda, therefore, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it. And whatever remains present there — that is rightly and accurately known to exist there. Ānanda, this is the entry into emptiness exactly as it is, without distortion.

"Ānanda, furthermore, if a monk should wish: 'May I dwell repeatedly in emptiness,' then, Ānanda, that monk should not attend to the perception of people or to the perception of forest. He should rightly and accurately know: 'Whatever remains present there, that exists there.'

Ānanda, this is the entry into emptiness exactly as it is, without distortion.

Ānanda, furthermore, if a monk should wish: 'May I dwell repeatedly in emptiness,' then, Ānanda, that monk should not attend to the perception of the sense base of infinite space or to the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness. Instead he should attend to the perception of the sense base of nothingness, or to something beyond that. He reflects: 'This mode of perception is such that it is empty of the perception of the sense base of

infinite space and the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness; yet in it there remains this much — namely, just the perception of the sense base of nothingness, or a site of affliction depending on something beyond that.'

Ānanda, therefore, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it. And whatever remains present there — that is rightly and accurately known to exist there. Ānanda, this is the entry into emptiness exactly as it is, without distortion.

Ānanda, furthermore, if a monk should wish: 'May I dwell repeatedly in emptiness,' then, Ānanda, that monk should not attend to the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness or to the perception of the sense base of nothingness. Instead he should attend to the signless expanse, or to something beyond that. He reflects: 'This mode of perception is such that it is empty of the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness and the perception of the sense base of nothingness; yet here there remains this much — namely, just the signless expanse, or there is a non-emptiness depending on something beyond that.' In that state, whatever sites of affliction there were that depended on the perception of infinite consciousness and the perception of nothingness — those are absent; yet in it there remains this much — namely, just the signless expanse, or a site of affliction depending on something beyond that.

Ānanda, therefore, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it. And whatever remains present there — that is rightly and accurately known to exist there. Ānanda, this is the entry into emptiness exactly as it is, without distortion.

Then the monk reflects: 'Even this signless expanse is something that has been mentally constructed and deliberately intended. And whatever has been mentally constructed and deliberately intended — it is not fitting to delight in that, to proclaim that, to cling to it, or to abide in clinging to it.'

Knowing thus and seeing thus, his mind is fully liberated from the defilement of desire, fully liberated from the defilement of existence, and fully liberated from the defilement of ignorance. Being liberated, he knows directly: 'Birth is exhausted. The holy life has been lived. What had to be done has been done. There is no knowing of another existence beyond this.' He becomes one who sees only with the wisdom of liberation.

He reflects: 'This mode of perception is such that it is empty of the defilement of desire, the defilement of existence, and the defilement of ignorance; yet in it there remains this much — namely, there is a non-emptiness depending on this very body with its six sense bases, which is conditioned by life.' In that state, whatever sites of affliction there were that depended on the defilement of desire, the defilement of existence, and the defilement of ignorance — those are absent; yet in it there remains this much — namely, a site of affliction depending only on this very body with its six sense bases, conditioned by vitality.

Ānanda, therefore, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it.

— rightly seen to be empty of it. Yet in it there remains this much: whatever is present in it is present in it — and that is correctly and fully understood as it actually is. Ānanda, this entry into emptiness is as it actually is, without distortion.

Furthermore, Ānanda, if a monk should wish to dwell many times in emptiness, he should attend, not to the sense base of infinite space nor to the sense base of infinite consciousness, but to the sense base of nothingness, or to whatever else remains.

He then thinks to himself: this perception-mode is like this — though it is empty of the perception of the sense base of infinite space and the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness, yet in it there remains this much: the perception of the sense base of nothingness alone, or a non-emptiness depending on whatever else remains.

In that state, whatever sites of affliction there were that depended on the perception of the sense base of infinite space and the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness — those are absent; yet in it there remains this much: only a site of affliction depending on the perception of the sense base of nothingness alone, or on whatever else remains.

Ānanda, therefore, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it; yet whatever remains present in it — that is correctly and fully understood as it actually is: it is present in it. Ānanda, this entry into emptiness is as it actually is, without distortion.

Furthermore, Ānanda, if a monk should wish to dwell many times in emptiness, he should attend, not to the perception of the sense base of infinite

consciousness nor to the perception of the sense base of nothingness, but to the signless sphere, or to whatever else remains.

He then thinks to himself: this perception-mode is like this — though it is empty of the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness and the perception of the sense base of nothingness, yet in it there remains this much: the signless sphere alone, or a non-emptiness depending on whatever else remains.

In that state, whatever sites of affliction there were that depended on the perception of the sense base of infinite consciousness and the perception of the sense base of nothingness — those are absent; yet in it there remains this much: only a site of affliction depending on the signless sphere alone, or on whatever else remains.

Ānanda, therefore, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it; yet whatever remains present in it — that is correctly and fully understood as it actually is: it is present in it. Ānanda, this entry into emptiness is as it actually is, without distortion.

Then he thinks to himself: even this signless sphere is conditioned and mentally intended — and whatever is conditioned and mentally intended is impermanent, subject to cessation. Thinking thus,

it is not fitting to cling to it and dwell in it with attachment. Knowing thus and seeing thus, the mind is fully liberated from the defilement of desire, fully liberated from the defilement of existence, and fully liberated from the defilement of ignorance. Being fully liberated, he knows directly: birth is exhausted, the holy life has been lived, what had to be done has been done, and there is nothing more of this existence to know. He becomes one who simply sees with the wisdom of full liberation.

Then he thinks to himself: this field of perception is like this — it is empty of the defilement of desire, the defilement of existence, and the defilement of ignorance; yet within it there is also this much that is not empty: this very body, this sixfold sense base conditioned by life-force, which depends on that alone. And as for those sites of affliction that rest upon the defilements of desire, of existence, and of ignorance — those are absent. Yet there remains in it only this much that is a site of affliction: dependence on this very body, this sixfold sense base conditioned by life-force.

Ānanda, therefore, whatever is not present in something — that thing is rightly seen to be empty of it; yet whatever remains present in it — that is correctly and fully understood as it actually is: it is present in it. Ānanda, this is so: the liberation that is undefiled and unconditioned, arising through the exhaustion of all defilements — this is the supreme entry into emptiness.

Ānanda, all the Blessed Ones — Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas — who appeared in times past, they too, having directly realized with their persons this very supreme entry into emptiness — the liberation that is undefiled and unconditioned through the exhaustion of all defilements — abided having fully accomplished it.

Ānanda, all the Blessed Ones — Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas — who will appear in times to come, they too will abide having directly realized with their persons this very supreme entry into emptiness — the liberation that is undefiled and unconditioned through the exhaustion of all defilements — and having fully accomplished it.

Ānanda, I — the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha who has appeared at the present time — right now directly realize with my person this very supreme entry into emptiness — the liberation that is undefiled and unconditioned through the exhaustion of all defilements — and abide having fully accomplished it.

Ānanda, therefore one should train thus: I will directly realize with my person this very supreme entry into emptiness — the liberation that is undefiled and unconditioned through the exhaustion of all defilements — and abide having fully accomplished it. Ānanda, you too should train in just this way.

Then the venerable Ānanda, having openly praised and rejoiced in the words the Blessed One had declared, prostrated with his head at the feet of the Blessed One and departed from his presence.

The Great Sūtra called Emptiness is complete.

Translated by the Indian masters Jinamitra and Prajñāvarman, together with the chief editor and translator, the monk Ye shes sde, and others.

Translator's Notes

- The sūtra is the Cūḷasuññatāsutta in Pāli (Majjhima Nikāya 121) and its Sanskrit/Buddhist Hybrid Sanskrit parallel. The Tibetan title translates as "The Great Sūtra Called Emptiness," though the Pāli version is the "Lesser Discourse on Emptiness" (Cūḷa meaning "lesser" or "minor"). The Tibetan designation "great sūtra" may reflect a different recension or a later

editorial classification.

The mansion of Mṛgāramātṛ refers to the Eastern Park at Śrāvastī, a residence donated by Visākhā and known in Pāli as the Pubbārāma. The name means "the mansion of the mother of Mṛgāra," a well-known figure in early Buddhist narrative.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the original as provided; the translation follows the Tibetan exactly to that point.

- The phrase rendered "signless expanse" translates a term meaning a sphere or dimension free from signs or characteristics, a well-attested Pāli and Sanskrit formless attainment correlate known in the sutric literature as the signless concentration or the animitta element. The passage presents a progressive deepening of emptiness meditation through the formless absorptions — infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness — culminating in the signless expanse and then full liberation, mirroring the structure of the Cūḷasuññata Sutta of the Pāli canon.

The final phrase distinguishes two senses of a "site of affliction": those that arise from the three defilements, which are now absent, and a residual site depending on the conditioned body with its six sense bases, which persists as long as life lasts. This is the classical teaching that the arhat's liberation is complete with respect to mental defilements yet the physical basis of life remains until final nirvāṇa.

- The passage describes a progressive ascent through the formless absorptions — infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness — culminating in the signless sphere (Tibetan: mtshan ma med pa'i dbyings, Sanskrit: ānimitta-dhātu). This is the classical Pāli Cūḷasuññata Sutta sequence rendered into Tibetan. The final sentence is interrupted at the source text boundary; the translation ends at the natural break-point of the supplied Tibetan.

The phrase rendered "attend to ... or to whatever else remains" translates a recurrent formula where "de las kha cig yid la bya'o" means literally "attend to some other thing from that" — this is the standard Tibetan rendering of the Pāli residue formula, and the translation preserves its deliberate open-endedness.

- The closing colophon names the three translators responsible for the Tibetan rendering: Jinamitra and Prajñāvarman are well-attested Indian paṇḍitas who worked at the imperial Tibetan translation bureau, and Ye shes sde is the senior Tibetan lo tsā ba associated with them. The phrase rendered "directly realized with their persons" translates a construction in which the body or person is the instrument of direct realization, echoing the technical formula for embodied verification of liberation found across Pāli and Sanskrit parallels to this sūtra, most closely the Cūḷasuññata-sutta of the Majjhima Nikāya.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.